

Give every early move a job

The opening prepares a playable middlegame. A useful move makes your pieces cooperate while meeting the position's immediate needs.

Contest central squares. Pieces near the center can often reach either side of the board. A central pawn move can claim space and free a bishop, but piece pressure can also contest the center.

Develop toward useful work. Place knights and bishops where they influence the game and have safe onward routes. Count useful pieces in play, not just the number of pieces that have moved.

Secure the king. Prepare castling while checking which side is safer. Castling into an open file or a ready attack can be a mistake even when it is legal.

Spend moves carefully. A queen excursion, repeated piece move, or flank pawn push should achieve something concrete. If it merely invites an attack, your opponent may develop while gaining time.

Keep the whole army in mind. Ask what your least active bishop or knight needs. A pawn move that frees one piece but blocks another may solve only half the problem.

Recheck after every reply. An opening setup is not an automatic sequence. A threat, hanging piece, or central break can make the usual next move inappropriate.

PRINCIPLES HAVE EXCEPTIONS

Capturing a free piece, stopping mate, or answering a direct threat can justify moving a piece twice or delaying development. Name the concrete reason before making the exception.

FURTHER READING

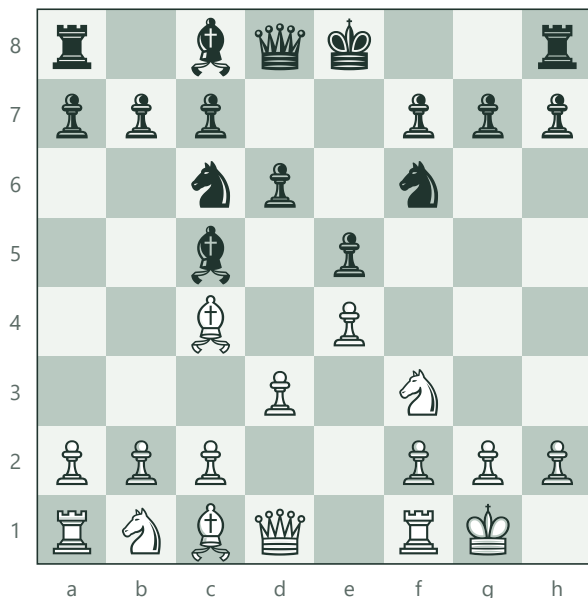
Opening principles - Chess.com

See the purpose behind the moves

A calm Italian Game example: follow the ideas, then look at the position that results.

MODEL SEQUENCE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. d3 Nf6 5. O-O d6



Position after 5...d6. White to move.

1. e4 e5

Both sides claim central space and release a bishop.

2. Nf3 Nc6

White develops with an attack on e5; Black develops while defending it.

3. Bc4 Bc5

The bishops enter useful diagonals. Both sides still have work to do.

4. d3 and 5. O-O

White supports the center and puts the king behind a pawn shield.

Find the unfinished work

White's b1-knight and c1-bishop still need useful roles. The queen will eventually move so the rooks can connect. Black still needs to finish development and decide when to castle. White can consider 6.Nc3; that is a sensible candidate, not a forced move.

Pause and explain

Why is d3 useful here? It supports e4 and opens the c1-bishop's diagonal. Why not immediately attack with only the queen? White still has undeveloped pieces, and a premature attack may leave them unable to help.

PRACTICE

Replay the sequence without notes. For each move, name what it attacks, what it supports, and which piece benefits. Then try a different legal reply and reassess from that position.

When you are out of familiar moves

Use a position-based routine instead of searching your memory for an opening name.

First, check immediate danger. Look for a threatened mate, an attacked queen, loose pieces, and a pawn that can be captured tactically. Defend a real threat before continuing a setup.

Compare development and kings. If your king is safe and your pieces are ready, opening central lines may help. If you are behind in development, opening the position can expose your own king.

Identify the next useful pawn break. A pawn break attacks the opponent's pawn formation. Before playing it, calculate captures and decide which file or diagonal will open for each side.

Develop with a plan. Choose a square that supports a central break, pressures a target, or improves coordination. Moving a knight to a square where it will immediately be chased may waste time.

Build a small personal repertoire

Keep one main first move as White and a manageable response to common White setups as Black. For each position you reach often, record the usual piece squares, a central pawn break, one tactical danger, and the kind of endgame that can arise. Add a few moves only after a real game shows why you need them.

CASTLING LEGALITY REMINDER

The king and the chosen rook must never have moved; the squares between them must be empty. The king may not castle while in check, cross an attacked square, or land on one. These are the standard-chess conditions; evaluate safety separately.

A useful post-game question

Find the first move where you could not explain your choice. Was the problem a missed threat, a poor piece square, or an unfamiliar pawn structure? Study that decision before memorizing a longer variation.

RULE REFERENCE: ARTICLE 3.8.2

FIDE Laws of Chess - handbook.fide.com/chapter/e012023